

# PATERNAL FOLLIES

Deve Gowda's dynastic impulses come to the fore as son Kumaraswamy fails to honour the power-sharing pact with BJP, leading to the imposition of President's rule in the state

Photographs by GIREESH GV



**CAUGHT IN THEIR OWN WEB:**  
(From left) Kumaraswamy, Mirajuddin Patel and Gowda of the JD (S)

■ By Stephen David

**H**aradanahalli Doddegowda Deve Gowda takes his job as the patriarch of Karnataka's first family of politics quite seriously. A civil engineer who lists agriculture as his profession in his Lok Sabha biosketch, this humble farmer—fumble harmer to the uncharitable ones—is not one to remain content with the fact that only one of his four sons has followed him as a chief minister of the state. His dynastic instincts are intact even as the state is in a political whirl, in the wake of his son Kumaraswamy's exit as chief minister.

To put the moment in a paternal perspective, Gowda goes back in time. "I am a poor farmer who became the

prime minister of India (in 1996) by God's grace," says the most favoured farmer in Indian politics, reclining on a beige sofa in his bungalow in south Bangalore's Padmanabhanagar. Outside, a formidable posse of security men is keeping the darshan-seeking villagers at bay.

Gowda's obsession with the benevolent gods is legendary—he visits shrines of every faith across the country regularly. From gifting a silver crown to the Infant Jesus's shrine in the city to hosting an iftaar party, Gowda is very democratic in his divine pursuits. He also consults several as-

trologers, just in case one of them has a forecast inimical to his fortunes.

When Gowda's son H.D. Kumaraswamy pulled the rug from under Dharam Singh's feet and walked off with 39 MLAs to form the JD(S)-BJP coalition government in February 2006,

Gowda threatened to kill himself. He even publicly said that his son's act was a sad day in his life. The huge drama was lapped up by the unsuspecting public but in his heart Gowda was happy that his son, at the age of 46, had become chief minister.

Although he threatened to disown his son

**Gowda is not content with the fact that only one of his sons has followed him as chief minister of the state.**